

PLAYOFFS, CHICAGO-STYLE

Cubs: Pete Crow-Armstrong becomes the seventh player to join 40-40 club as Cubs clinch postseason spot.

White Sox: The South Siders complete an incredible turnaround from three 100-loss seasons to playoff team.



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE



CHARLIE RIEDEL/AP

WINNER OF 29 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 25, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Aldermen advance parking meter sale

Some praise new perks, but others concerned city still getting bad deal

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Aldermen gave initial approval Thursday to the sale of Chicago's infamously privatized parking meter system from one owner to another, but not before praise for new perks met concerns that the city is once again getting a subpar deal.

As the City Council's Finance Committee voted nearly unanimously to advance the \$2.53 billion deal for New York investment firm Stonepeak Partners to take over the five decades remaining on the 75-year lease, some aldermen praised the deal as a once-unthinkable score.

But others gritted their teeth and expressed frustration that, upon a closer look, the provisions aimed at enticing them to approve the deal weren't as valuable as they'd expected.

Still, by the time the meeting ended, aldermen had agreed the new terms made the disastrous 2008 privatization of the city's once-public system a little bit better.

See **PARKING** on Page A5

Trump touts bond with China's Xi

Sides plan to touch on Taiwan, Iran, AI, economies at talks

By Aamer Madhani, Didi Tang and Michelle L. Price
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump on Thursday hailed the "truly great friendship" he has forged with Xi Jinping as the Chinese leader began his highly anticipated state visit by pressing for the world's two biggest economies to work more closely together to avoid friction as they compete.

While Trump has many thorny issues to discuss with the president of America's biggest economic rival, he focused on his long relationship with Xi as the two gathered with aides for opening remarks before formal talks.

"From the time of my first election in 2016, President Xi and I have forged a friendship, a truly great friendship, actually, built on mutual respect and the vital interests of our people," Trump said.

China has resisted the Trump administration's urgings — and

See **VISIT** on Page A9



The Erker family of St. Louis and California listen to a musical performance before the beatification Mass for Fulton Sheen at the Dome at America's Center in St. Louis on Thursday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'Overwhelmed with joy'

Tens of thousands gather for the beatification of Archbishop Fulton Sheen

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Famed evangelist and Emmy-winning TV host Archbishop Fulton Sheen once said, "It does not require much time to make us saints. It requires only much love."

The media pioneer from central Illinois who once captivated millions of American viewers with his faith-filled primetime programming is now one step closer to sainthood.

Tens of thousands of Catholic faithful gathered for Sheen's historic beatification in St. Louis

on Thursday, marking the first Illinois native to reach this milestone on the path to canonization.

Bishop Louis Tylka of the Diocese of Peoria, which opened Sheen's cause for canonization almost a quarter-century ago, donned Sheen's iconic pectoral cross — famously worn by the American prelate during his television broadcasts — for the beatification Mass and celebration events held throughout the day at the Dome at America's Center. "I am overwhelmed with joy," Tylka said. "I know this is a



Sheen

moment of grace for not just the church in Peoria, not just the church in the United States, but really for the church around the world."

Filipino Cardinal Luis Antonio Tagle, a top Vatican leader of global evangelization, presided over the Mass, which drew a crowd of roughly 50,000 worshippers from almost every state as well as 10 countries, including large groups from Poland, Italy and Brazil, according to Diocese of Peoria officials.

Tagle noted the local connection between Chicago native Pope

Leo XIV and Sheen, who was born and raised just a few hours away in the same state.

"I bring to you the paternal greetings of his holiness Pope Leo XIV, who rejoices in the beatification of his fellow countryman, his fellow Illinoisan and brother bishop," he said.

Prior to the liturgical service, an exhibition hall at the Dome featured more than a hundred displays of Catholic books, artwork and religious gifts, as well as representatives of various faith ministries from across the country.

See **SHEEN** on Page A4

CPS' decades-long enrollment decline continues



Chicago Board of Education member Michilla Blaise joins activists to call to extend the moratorium on school closures, consolidations and phase-outs before it expires, during a news conference outside Chicago Public Schools headquarters on Thursday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

11,537 fewer students this year as number of school-age kids shrinks

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago Public Schools enrollment dropped 11,537 students this year, continuing a decades-long decline amid a shrinking number of school-age children.

CPS CEO Macquiline King said Thursday that the district's 20th-day enrollment — which represents the official count for the school year — was 304,687, a decline of 3.7% since last fall. Still, the district appears to have restored its position as the nation's third-largest school district,

behind New York City and Los Angeles.

Since 2010, overall enrollment in CPS has declined 24%, or nearly 100,000 students.

CPS was the nation's third-largest school district for decades before falling behind Miami-Dade County Public Schools in Florida in 2022. But that district's enrollment dropped by 19,000 students this August, leaving its total enrollment at about 300,000 — just behind CPS.

Public school enrollment has plunged across the country, mostly due to declining birth rates. U.S. fertility rates last peaked in 2007, prior to the Great Recession. As those cohorts of children grow

See **CPS** on Page A2

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 68 L: 55
SAT. H: 69 L: 55
SUN. H: 70 L: 53
FULL WEATHER REPORT A14

INDEX

Almanac A9
Comics D6-D7
Crossword D7
Editorials A6
Horoscope D6
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A9
Sudoku D7
Television D5

179th year No. 268
© Chicago Tribune

